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Saffron Demography, Common Wisdom, Aspirations and Uneven Governmentalities

'Saffron Demography' has been instrumental in perpetuating myths relating to claimed differences between Hindu and Muslim populations. This paper examines this by now 'common wisdom' in the light of contemporary demographic reality in India. Based on extensive research in a western Uttar Pradesh district, it argues that the scale of Hindu-Muslim demographic differences has been exaggerated, and that the explanations provided for these differences are equally pernicious. Instead, it attempts an understanding of these 'causes' leading to differences in fertility through an analysis of the kind of governmentality seen in post-independence India and argues for new policy initiatives that avoid the punitive victim-blaming approach that has thus far been the norm.

ROGER JEFFERY, PATRICIA JEFFERY

'Saffron Demography' is a set of pernicious myths about claimed differences between Hindu and Muslim populations.¹ It has been repeated so often, and with so much authority, by right-wing Hindu politicians and the mass media, that it has become part of a 'common wisdom'. Yet in creating a demonised 'other' (the over-sexed Muslim man and his over-fertile Muslim wife/wives) it has contributed to the very phenomenon that it (superficially, at least) wishes to control, more rapid population growth among Muslims. In this paper we set out the contours of this common wisdom and assess its relationship to India's contemporary demographic reality. We then look at how the differences between core and marginalised groups can be understood as one result of incomplete and uneven governmentality (one that is changing its nature under the pressures of globalised neoliberalism). Finally we briefly address ways of 'strengthening the capacity to aspire' so that poor Muslims (among other socially excluded groups) can relate in more productive ways to 'the future-oriented logic of development' and find ways to 'contest and alter the conditions of their own poverty' [Appadurai 2004:70].

Saffron Demography is concerned mostly with the relationships between religion on the one hand and fertility and population growth on the other; it is rarely concerned with mortality, and migration is mentioned only to highlight the possible effects of illegal immigration, not with reference to the full range of migration flows within and beyond India's boundaries. In part, this reflects how the 'overpopulation discourse' is "the most important mobilisation of 'population' as an object of knowledge for governance in modern India" [Hodges 2004:1163]. But the obsessive concern with Muslim fertility in itself demonstrates the Islamophobic basis for the discussions. Such a focus produces an unbalanced account, one that ignores central and urgent demographic debates in India today – such as the effects of sex-selective abortions and female infanticide on the juvenile sex ratio (and thus, before long, on the adult sex ratio), or the likely effects of a looming AIDS crisis – that have been conducted with almost no consideration of their differential effects on members of the different religious communities.

Instead, saffron demographers (though they rarely seem to have a formal training in demography) have rather focused on changes in the religious proportions of the population from one census to the next, and have argued that Hindus in India face a minority status within some specifiable period in the future. Most professional demographers, however, would argue that all such projections are fraught with so many unknown variables that it is foolish to take them seriously. Consider only the possibility (much proclaimed but still not taken seriously in India) that an AIDS pandemic is beginning to sweep the country: even the more conservative estimates of the demographic effects of such a catastrophe would change all the predictions based on extrapolating from current experience. The writers from the Hindu Right, however, are less concerned with shedding light than with generating heat: scare-mongering is their purpose and their language betrays this goal, as when they talk of 'the Muslim population in India exploding' and 'the Hindu population declining' [Rai nd:16]. Such writers are in a long tradition of portraying the social and political influence of a population in direct proportion to its size, and making the exaggerated claims that 'Hindus are dying' [Datta 1993, 1999] – discussions generated in large measure by the introduction by the British of decennial censuses in which one of the few 'facts' recorded and published was the religion of the population [Appadurai 1993; Cohn 1987].

Here we will set out some of the wider implications of Saffron Demography, and the common wisdom it supports and draws from. Then drawing particularly (but not only) on our research in western Uttar Pradesh, we argue that saffron demographers exaggerate the scale of the Muslim-Hindu demographic differences; that they give a generally false and pernicious account of the causes of these differences; that we can understand these 'causes' more generally through an analysis of the partial form that governmentality has taken in post-independence India; and that a fuller understanding implies policy initiatives that avoid the punitive victim-blaming approach that is only too common.

I Stereotypes and Stigma

The significance of the recent media debate over the proportions of the Indian population from different religious groups is not that the *Organiser* should run a series of articles entitled 'The population bomb', 'Census politics with Muslim numbers' (September 19, 2004), 'Canards can't hide Muslim population explosion' (October 3, 2004) or 'Census – demography and unity' (October 10, 2004). We expect nothing better from the mouthpiece of the RSS than articles designed to increase inter-communal hostility. It is not even that apparently respectable parts of the Indian media – English-medium as well as the vernacular press – should run similar articles (see, for example, *The Pioneer*, on September 21, 22 and 28, 2004). The significant and frightening aspect is how many Indians, if asked, would not only say that there are significant demographic differences between members of the Muslim minority and those in the Hindu majority but go on to accuse Muslims of following conscious anti-nationalist strategies in their higher fertility rates. Our own experience of this comes from repeated discussions in India and elsewhere. In Bijnor – where we have carried out most of our research since 1982 – we have been readily plied with such communalist discourses, often connected with the notion that Bijnor itself was backward because of its relatively large proportion of Muslims.² These discourses draw on Islamophobic ideas – ideas that have a long provenance, and can be traced, in western Europe, to the impacts of the Crusades, the wars against the Moors in 15th century Spain, and the colonisation of the 18th and 19th centuries [Said 1978]. Anti-Muslim views have almost as long a history within India; and (as in the rest of the world) they seem to be growing rather than declining. There is, then, a common wisdom that many people are aware of and to which they subscribe – in some measure at least – that tends to essentialise Hindus and Muslims; that ascribes to Muslims anti-nationalist views or behaviour; and that is highly gendered in its implications.

Movements associated with politicised religion – especially the Hindu Right – have often essentialised the terms 'Hindu' and 'Muslim' [Bacchetta 1993, 1994; Basu 1995; Hasan 1988]. To essentialise identities is to assume that those that are given at birth (gender, nationality, and, in the case of India, membership of a religious category) are the only authentic sources of identity. 'Authenticity' is often central in identity politics, yet it rests on deeply problematic assumptions about internally homogeneous and timeless cultures, for ever distinguishable from one another [Bhabha 1990; Hall 1992; Said 1993]. Such essentialism is not the monopoly of the Hindu Right, of course. Organisations such as Tablighi Jama'at work to expunge 'cultural' and 'religious' syncretism from Muslim practice in south Asia [Gardner 1999; Metcalf 1999].

Essentialising Hindus and Muslims promotes the political interests of some self-proclaimed Muslim leaders, as well as those in the Hindu Right, because it works to separate Muslims from the rest of Indians. Whereas the Muslims engaged in this task often justify their cause with reference to the next world, those in the Hindu right do so in order to target Muslims for punitive and hostile actions in this world, and in these ways to lead Hindus to focus on a unity as Hindus and to downplay the diverse and often conflicting interests based on their caste, class, occupation or gender identities. The Hindu Right in India also tends to essentialise the 'Hindu woman' and differentiate her from the 'Muslim woman', and we will discuss the significance of this below. Arguments like this are also used by some Muslim

religious leaders, who claim that Muslims, as an endangered minority, must act as a unity, despite their own differences and internal divisions; and that what happens to Muslim women should be their responsibility alone. Neither account, we argue, bears close relationship to social lives as lived.

The loyalty of Indian Muslims to the Indian nation has often been questioned by the Hindu Right, which accuses them of having a political agenda – to take over India. Some of this derives from resentment over Partition, seen as entirely a Muslim responsibility. It is reinforced by rumours of Pakistani spies, the portrayal of India's enemies in Bollywood films, the immediate recourse to 'foreign hand' (=Pakistani influence) explanations in any disaster, and by claiming that there are large numbers of Bangladeshi immigrants, whether in border regions or in Delhi. High Muslim fertility is portrayed as part of the same agenda. In this paranoid discourse, then, Muslims pose a threat to the Indian nation, both by making a major contribution to excessive population growth, and because, when their numbers permit it, they will provide Pakistan with the opportunity to invade and take India over. These ideas are reinforced through media controlled by the Hindu Right, by the actions and comments of members of the judiciary who support the Hindu Right, as well as by political speeches on behalf of the BJP, the main political voice of the Hindu Right. They reinforce the idea that Muslims are united, and this is an impetus for demanding Hindu unity in the face of this threat.

Although the BJP lost power in the 2004 election, this did not reflect a major swing away from right wing parties (but rather the effects of opposition alliances and voting against incumbents), and right-wing Hindus are still well-entrenched within the mass media, the judiciary and the schools and colleges. We doubt whether public support for the 'common wisdom' will drop very much, despite the Congress-led coalition's steps (such as removing the worst anti-Muslim stereotypes from the history textbooks) to reduce the official support for these views. As during previous Congress governments, the Hindu Right will argue that Congress governments 'pamper' and 'appease' Indian Muslims in order to secure the 'Muslim vote bank'. Like the rest of those arguments which assert that Indian Muslims share overriding identifications as Muslims, this has little basis in truth. Muslims tended to vote for Congress until the late 1980s, but not uniformly so: sizeable numbers also voted for parties championing the interests of the urban working classes and the rural dispossessed, and this has become more common in recent years. Recent electoral studies suggest that upper-caste Hindus now form more of a 'vote-bank' for the BJP than do any other social groups (barring the Yadavs) for other parties in UP [Verma 2002; Yadav 2002]. Nonetheless, the notion that Muslims vote en masse is an important part of the common wisdom, and carries the clear presumption that such behaviour poses a threat to national unity.

Gender issues – images of male and female citizens – are often prominent in nationalist discourses, and throughout south Asia, movements associated with politicised religion have accorded these issues a central place. High profile politicised religion in India – as elsewhere in the region and beyond – is deeply gendered in its manifestations, whether in the offerings of its ideologues or in the operation of distinctive systems of family law [Anthias and Yuval-Davis 1992; Basu 1995; Mann 1994; Moghadam 1994]. In India, organisations of the Hindu Right have constructed Hindu women as respected mothers of the nation, expected to rear pure and patriotic Hindu citizens, or to protect the birthplace of Ram with the ferocity of a mother defending her children's

interests [Chhachhi 1991, 1994; Mazumdar 1992, 1995; Sarkar 1991, 1995]. Similarly, they have created an essentialised 'Muslim woman' oppressed by 'Islamic tradition', victimised by her own menfolk (caricatured as prone to violence, sexually voracious and polygamous), and in need of rescue by gallant and fair-minded Hindu men [Bacchetta 1994; Kapur and Cossman 1995]. The 'vulnerability' of Muslim women was a key issue in the Shah Bano affair (which culminated in legislation supposedly denying divorced Muslim women legal redress to obtain maintenance after divorce) and latterly, but mercifully less dramatically, in relation to the 'triple *talâq*' (the false claim that because a Muslim man theoretically can divorce his wife at will they therefore do so, in large numbers) [Agnes 1994; Engineer 1987; Hasan 1989, 1994; Pathak and Rajan 1989].

Muslim men are often represented as aggressive: when 'riots' occur, these can be characterised as the fault of hot-blooded Muslim men, rather than (as is much more often the case) attacks on Muslims or provocations by Hindus who know that the state apparatus will normally protect them [Brass 2003]. But in addition (with direct relevance for demographic concerns) this aggression is said to have sexual implications. The 'Muslim woman' as victim of her own menfolk figures centrally in the rhetoric of the Hindu Right [Bacchetta 1994; Basu 1993, 1995, 1999; Hasan 1999; Kapur and Cossman 1995; Sarkar 1993]. Women and population issues are thus entwined as an enduring thread in these images: the Muslim woman is represented as a victim and backward, major reasons for her supposed high fertility. Although the provisions of Muslim and Hindu family law alike are discriminatory on grounds of sex, portrayals of the Muslim woman oppressed by Islamic doctrine, seclusion practices and so forth have taken root in public discourse [Kapur and Cossman 1995; Kishwar 1986; Parashar 1992]. The common wisdom, then, is that Muslims have more children than members of other religious groups, because Muslim women are more backward, more constrained by religion and more closely controlled by their menfolk. Muslim men have more children than others because they are sexually uncontrolled (perhaps linked to their consumption of meat), because they can take more than one wife, they can divorce easily, and they follow the wishes of their religious leaders, whose desire is for Muslims to outnumber Hindus in order to take political power. Thus *purdah*, polygamy, educational backwardness and women's status are all rolled together to 'explain' supposed high fertility among Muslims.

The common wisdom thus portrays Muslims and Hindus as essentially different; Muslims as a threat to the nation; and Muslim men as the main cause of the backwardness of Muslim women and the large families they have. This picture is, of course, highly misleading. The common wisdom depends on stereotypes peddled by members of the Hindu Right, exaggerating the size and stability of fertility differentials, and creating untenable explanations for their false claims. Our argument rests on very different ideas about identity, religion and demographic change, which we will discuss in Section III; we first turn to examine briefly the evidence on fertility differentials.

II

How Significant Are Inter-religious Fertility Differentials?

Non-saffron demographers have been reluctant to acknowledge the possibility of inter-religious differences in fertility levels. We fully share this reluctance: it is easy for saffron 'demographers' to twist such material and quote it out of

context. Further, until recently, world-class demographers have not established the extent to which apparent differentials were not really linked to religious group membership but were spurious, resulting from the different regional, residential, class and educational locations of Muslims compared to other religious groups. Such analyses are now being carried out. In recently published studies, Dharmalingam and Morgan have demonstrated that correlations between religion and two indicators of fertility – desire for an additional child and use of contraceptives – persist across India, even after controlling for (inter alia) the effects of residence, class and educational experience [Dharmalingam and Morgan 2004; Morgan et al 2002]. Muslim women are more likely to want an additional child, at any specific parity, than are Hindu, Sikh or Christian women in otherwise very similar situations, and they are less likely to use contraception. This evidence is by no means sufficient on its own to establish fertility differences, based as it is on only 1993 NFHS data and dealing only with indirect indicators of fertility. Although other crude indicators – such as child-woman ratios – seem to point in the same direction, we have yet to see comparable multi-level analyses of parity-progression ratios, total fertility rates or completed family sizes (which would take infant and child mortality more directly into account). Nor do we yet know when such differentials arose, whether they are growing or declining, nor what might account for the size of the differentials in different parts of the country (why, for example, Muslim fertility in MP is apparently below that of comparable Hindus).

International experience suggests, however, that studies using other indicators are unlikely to change the conclusions reached by Dharmalingam and Morgan. For the purposes of this article we therefore accept that Muslim fertility in India is somewhat higher than fertility among members of other religious categories who occupy otherwise similar social, economic and geographical positions.

But because the scale of inter-religious fertility differences has routinely been exaggerated, it is important to be clear about some additional facts. Fertility among Muslims is far below 'natural' fertility for all groups of Indian Muslims: irrespective of the views of 'maulwis' who deny that Islam supports family limitation, Muslims are limiting their families (as indeed are good Catholic Italians and Spaniards, among others). They are doing so more when others around them are also doing so: thus fertility rates for Muslims in Kerala are well below those in UP, and those Muslims who have experienced more schooling, are wealthier and live in towns have lower fertility than those with less schooling, poorer and rural. Muslim Indians are not radically different from their neighbours in their fertility experiences: but they have responded more slowly to wider social processes than have those neighbours.

III

Explanations of Religious Fertility Differentials

There seems to be something about being a Muslim in India today, therefore, that tends towards them having slightly higher fertility, on average, than being a member of another religious group. What is the cause of that difference? In framing an answer to that question we cannot talk at the level of the nation as a whole, let alone on the basis of some claimed unity of Muslims worldwide. We restrict our comments to that part of India we know best (Bijnor district, western UP, perhaps some of the areas elsewhere in UP) and leave to later research investigation of how relevant these considerations are elsewhere. UP Muslims, at 30.7 million, make up about 22 per cent of India's 138.2 million

Muslims, and more than one-third of UP's Muslims (10.5 million) live in the west of UP: a priori what we describe may have relevance to understanding the position of a substantial proportion of India's Muslims. Nonetheless, UP's Muslims have distinctive class and residence positions, not the same as Muslims elsewhere in India [Shariff 1995]. On the other hand, north Indian Muslims and Hindus share very similar domestic arrangements, property rights, linguistic patterns and diet. A distinctive UP flavour to Islam is striking to outside observers, despite the divisions connected with the aftermath of Partition and the recent communalisation of politics [Ahmad 1973, 1976, 1981; Hasan 1991, 1997; Mann 1992].

Despite the path-breaking work of Jack Caldwell [Caldwell et al 1988] and the recent critical collections [Greenhalgh 1995; Szreter et al 2004] it is apparently still necessary to justify the role of small-scale studies within demography. Large-scale quantitative censuses and surveys are, of course, valuable sources. But they share some weaknesses. In general, the larger the population surveyed, the smaller the number of questions that can be asked and the greater the challenges to the validity and reliance that can be placed on the answers. Census enumerators may do a good job as far as total populations are concerned (though as residents in UP during both the 1991 and 2001 Censuses we were never asked to provide the census-takers with any information) but the temptation to cut corners on many other aspects of the detailed forms is enormous. All large-scale surveys have to depend on large numbers of often ill-motivated assistants, who have less commitment to data quality than do the principal investigators. In small-scale surveys (where data quality is a central concern, and where people can be asked a much wider range of questions, with repeated visits if necessary, and it is possible to contextualise their statements in their observed behaviour) the reverse problems ensue (numbers are insufficient to allow for the isolation of the impact of multiple variables, and conclusions may be seen as insufficiently robust to inform policy). It does not help, however, that mainstream demographers are unable to appreciate the weaknesses of their favoured, survey methodology and pour scorn on small-scale studies (see, e.g. Reddy 2003).³ Yet it has long been axiomatic that both methods have their strengths: small-scale studies can generate hypotheses for testing through larger-scale studies; and (as Dharmalingam and Morgan, 2004, argue) one role that can be played by analyses of large-scale data sets is to help select appropriate questions for small-scale studies to address, in particular issues of explanation and choosing between alternative ways of understanding national patterns.

One of the benefits of local studies is that they help us to avoid essentialised models of explanation. As against those (like both the Hindu Right and conservative Muslim leaders) who see communal identities as fixed and central to how people see themselves, our research supports those who see social identities as relatively fluid, and boundaries between competing groupings that are specific to particular times and places [Jenkins 1996]. Communal identities are negotiated and socially constructed rather than natural or 'essential' [Barth 1970]. Claims about fundamental loyalties are continually being challenged and reassessed, in Bijnor, in the face of challenges from cross-cutting and competing sources of identity (gender, class, caste) or countervailing tendencies that stress people's common humanity [Jeffery and Jeffery 1999]. Yet distinctions that seem small-scale and even trivial to an outsider can be compellingly real – if not entirely stable – markers of difference to people on the ground, and they can have immense social and political significance. 'Hindu' and 'Muslim' are provisional and partial categories,

sometimes relevant to people's behaviour, sometimes irrelevant, sometimes internally fragmented, not always providing clear bases for action.

Flexibility and fluidity in people's identifications undermines any attempt to 'explain' behaviour with reference to supposedly fixed and dominant identities as 'Hindu' or 'Muslim'. Countervailing voices claim a common humanity with a common origin and destination, beside which mere matters of ritual and custom ('rit', 'riwāj') are of negligible importance. Such rhetorics lose their force, for example, at times of riots or police attacks. But at other times, vocabularies that sub-divide the categories 'Hindu' and 'Muslim' along caste and sub-caste lines, for example, when candidates are selected for elections, acquire a particularly heightened political salience [Bétéille 1992; Engineer (ed) 1991; Jeffery and Jeffery 1997].⁴ These multiple roots of identification all have some purchase on how people see themselves and are seen by others, on how they behave, and on such relatively tangible outcomes as the allocations of health centres and schools to villages, or the accessibility of these facilities to particular groups of women and children, and thus to some of the proximate or more distant causes of fertility decline.

There is then a danger of reifying and rigidifying the contrasts between Hindus and Muslims, and ignoring the parallels and similarities, for example, in domestic and gender politics [Jeffery et al 1989; Jeffery and Jeffery 1996, 1997] that can emerge from detailed local studies – even if these insights cannot be generalised immediately to other settings.⁵ People's identifications are not carved in stone, nor do their loyalties have finality and stability. Nonetheless, important identities are meaningful locally: everyday speech and practice ensures that people are aware of the religious and caste membership of the people they engage with. What we have called everyday communalism [Jeffery and Jeffery 1999] is not just a question of there being Hindus and Muslims living in the area, but also that they engage in stereotyping of one another and that they are differentially placed in structures of power and influence in the area, with very different effects on fertility (and probably also on mortality). People are responded to (and act) in part on the basis of these stereotypes and beliefs. We need to consider the effects of such interactions without assuming that they are based on real differences that accord with the stereotypes, as well as to recognise that the existence of the stereotypes provides bases of action, both among the members and the outsiders. In other words, we reject essentialist accounts (based on the innate characteristics of Muslims) in favour of interactionist ones (based on the effects of interactions between Muslims and others, in particular the agents of the state). In our work in Bijnor we argued that the fertility differences between (Hindu) jats and (Muslim) sheikhs in the two villages we studied was not a result of conscious religious and political strategies by the sheikhs (though the jats were to some extent using fertility for collective purposes). We also suggested that sheikhs were neither irrational nor ignorant of the benefits and costs of schooling (and thus, to some extent, by extension, of fertility limitation). A better approach to understanding fertility outcomes was provided by a political economy of religious community membership.

Bijnor has a relatively large Muslim population – like several other districts in western Uttar Pradesh, its towns have a Muslim majority, with 67 per cent of the urban population in 2001; more unusually, the rural population is 34 per cent Muslim. Some villages in Bijnor district are dominated by particular Hindu castes, some with no substantial settlements of Muslims, many have evenly balanced Hindu and Muslim populations and yet

others are exclusively or largely Muslim. There are distinctive and separate Muslim institutions and class and caste structures, to a greater degree than in areas where Muslims form a small minority. But although Bijnor Muslims are diverse and located in a range of class positions, from (mainly small) landowners and businessmen to landless labourers, from cattle traders to barbers and midwives, they are to a considerable measure socially excluded from positions of power and influence in the district.

Brahmans dominate trade and commerce, while jats dominate agriculture and small-scale rural industries (like sugar production). The scheduled castes have access to several government schemes and also benefit locally because Bijnor is a 'reserved constituency' (restricted to scheduled caste candidates) in the Lok Sabha elections. Mayavati won the seat for the BSP in the 1980s, but in the 1991 elections the Lok Sabha constituency was won by the BJP, who retained it in 1996 and 1998, only to lose it to the combined candidate of the Samajwadi Party and Rashtriya Lok Dal in 2004. In the elections for the UP legislative assembly, after a clean sweep of all seven Bijnor seats in 1991, the BJP has lost ground to other parties: in 2002 the BJP held three seats, with two going to the SP and one each to the BSP and CPI. Although Muslims constitute 42 per cent of the district's population, only one of these UP assembly members is a Muslim.

Muslims also have different experiences of the state: fewer (in proportion to their numbers in Bijnor, many fewer) of them are employed by the state (as teachers, health workers or village extension workers, let alone as policemen or land revenue officials). They also have weaker access to the benefits that the state provides. In schooling, for example, government schools in or near Muslim villages are more poorly resourced than those in or near villages dominated by Hindu or SC populations. Government schools have been steadily saffronised since the 1930s at least [Oesterheld 2005], but privatisation of secondary schooling has overcome neither the marginalisation of Urdu nor the difficulties that Muslim girls, especially rural ones, have in accessing schooling. Primary and secondary schools are more likely to be sited conveniently for dominant castes, and girls from all subordinated groups are vulnerable to sexual harassment if they travel beyond their 'home' areas after puberty [Jeffery et al 2005]. Similar difficulties beset Muslim women's access to government and private health services [Jeffery 2000].

We argue that this experience of social exclusion and marginalisation goes a very long way to helping us understand the differences in demographic indicators (fertility, but also mortality and sex ratio) that have emerged in Bijnor and (probably) other parts of western UP if not further afield. The crucial factor differentiating the fertility regimes of the jats and the sheikhs was the jats' relative success in the off-farm employment market. Jats can aspire to educate their sons and place them in good employment, and to educate their daughters and arrange their marriages to educated young men with off-farm employment who would command increasingly larger dowries. By contrast, the sheikhs lacked access to influential people and they were almost completely excluded from sought-after employment. Sheikh men remained locked into an agrarian economy, supplemented with incomes from migrant artisans in towns. Investing in schooling made little sense and they had little incentive to limit their fertility – calculations that also applied to smaller and poorer Hindu and Muslim groups in rural Bijnor. In these respects, then, there is nothing essentially 'Muslim' about the sheikhs' fertility regime, any more than there is something 'Hindu' about that of the jats.

IV Religion, Fertility and the State

It is certainly possible at this point to 'blame' the family planning programme for its failings: the compulsion it used during the Emergency, and the 'target' approach that dominated until very recently. Here we want to look in a slightly different way, to consider what the changing nature of the family planning programme tells us about the nature of the state. We start from the Foucauldian insight that the modern state increasingly works through 'governmentality' rather than direct rule: that is, by working to produce self-regulating persons who are motivated to act as the state wishes them to [Foucault 1991]. In the Indian case, two of the main ways in which the state can be seen to try to produce this result are the family planning and primary education programmes. For example, family planning propaganda disseminates messages that 'individual planning and agency' will provide 'the ultimate answer to global issues such as population growth'. This approach leaves 'the poorest and most subordinate members of society' to bear the major burden of social change [Chatterjee and Riley 2001:840]. Recent work on the 'post-colonial' state suggests, however, that such programmes are always and inevitably partial and uneven [Hart 2004; Watts 2003]. The state cannot be 'all-seeing', and local state actors are forced to compromise on programme goals in order to get their jobs done [Li 1999; Gupta 2001]. As David Mosse has recently argued, staff in development projects (and in many social welfare programmes) may work hard to sustain (socially produced) interpretations of their work that appear to be successful [Mosse 2004:8]. In doing so, they inevitably focus on the 'accessible' populations. But 'accessibility' is socially produced, and depends in part on these populations' own characteristics, networks, and preferences. Socially excluded groups – like Muslims, poorly represented within the ranks of the local state officials – remain relatively marginalised.

New approaches in demographic work [Kreager 2004] are beginning to reconsider how demographic changes are linked to changes in the nature of the state. But demographic projects are no longer just matters for the Indian nation state: like other social programmes (education and health in particular), the population programme in a state like UP is a key example of how governmentality is being 'instituted anew on a global scale' [Gupta 1998:321]. Certainly, the increasingly interventionist role of World Bank funding of UP's fiscal deficit in general, and its social programmes in particular, lend credence to this view.

The Indian family planning programme is, arguably, 'a conjunctural and crisis-ridden enterprise' that 'engenders its own mode of resistance and makes, meets, moulds, or is contested by new subjects' [Gupta 2001:69]. As Chatterjee and Riley also point out, 'the way that individuals accommodate, resist, or adapt to hegemonic ideology may vary depending on race, class, caste, gender, religion, geographic location, rural or urban origins, and education' [Chatterjee and Riley 2001:840]. By demonising those who resist or adapt the attempts by the state to persuade them to regulate themselves in the interests of the good of all – the classic family planning messages – attention is drawn away from the underlying problems of the programme, and the kind of state-citizen relationship it presumes and works to produce.

Given the long-standing nature of how Muslims have been understood in India, we can ask why the current conjuncture gives such understandings particular relevance: why now? In addition to the effects of post 9/11 scapegoating, we might also use notions of neoliberal governmentality to understand contemporary

exigencies. Hart notes that neoliberalism is best seen not as 'less government' but as 'a new modality of government', a process of 'responsibilisation' that often goes along with 'new or intensified invocations of 'community' as a sector' (2004:92, emphases as in the original). Such processes may be less intense in India than in many other parts of the world, but there are resonances here as well. To take only UP, we can see that the social project of the 'developmental' state remains incomplete. Its social failures (the remnants of preventable communicable diseases like polio, of high fertility, of low female literacy, etc) pose a particular challenge for a public sector that is now supposed to be withdrawing from prime responsibility to optimise the health, life and productivity of its population. UP should be populated by individuals who do not need to be threatened with punishment in order for them to behave in the desired fashion, because they have been remade into subject-citizens who want to behave in that way. Muslims are merely the most visible among those who appear not to be 'active citizens' who can manage their own risks but are one of the classic 'targeted populations' who are seen to need new technologies of agency to get them to behave in desired ways [Dean 1999].

V What Is To Be Done?

The standard response to an issue is to propose some governmental action to remedy it. In this case the issue is much exaggerated and the likely policy responses (developing mass media campaigns oriented to sell family planning to Muslims, finding maulwis willing to endorse family limitation, or even targeting Muslim girls to get them into school) are likely not only to be seen as and to become punitive but also to be unsuccessful in their own terms.

Limited policy changes are still desirable, however. We would point to three, amongst many possibilities. Firstly, within the traditional spheres of health and family planning, action should be taken to continue to open them up to local initiative and make them more responsive to local groups. Unfortunately, to use conscious policy initiatives to overcome social exclusion in health and family planning services requires a change in the orientation of local health workers which is as desirable as it is implausible, at least in caste- and religiously-conscious UP. But continuing to reduce the pressures on people to limit their families is highly likely, within a relatively short period of time, to help women and men to move to new ways of planning their families: that is how governmentality works. A programme that seriously engaged with women's fears about childbirth and child deaths, with their own concerns for the effects on their health of bearing excessive numbers of children and about the disastrous effects on households of maternal and child illnesses, would provide a context in which couples come to their own judgments about the desirability of small families.

Secondly, it would help to make schooling attractive. The signs and symbols of majoritarian dominance must be removed, and marginalised populations – not just Muslims – need realistic chances of getting better jobs as a result of their schooling. If schooling becomes universal, households will inevitably move towards smaller numbers of children. Unfortunately, that will increase the pressure to ensure that at least one of them is a boy, including among Muslims (who are largely uninvolved at present). Furthermore, men who are less attractive (socially, economically, physically) will be left with reduced chances of marriage. To overcome these undesirable side-effects we need policies designed to reduce patriarchal norms and improve employment possibilities for women.

The third requirement is a serious effort to reform the coercive mechanisms of the UP state. At the level of people's everyday experiences of the local state this means finding ways of involving state activists who are more representative of the ~~full~~ range of local populations as mediators. At present, no-one outside the charmed circle of the well-connected, wealthy and powerful trust either the regular constabulary or the armed police. The police are brought in to further personal ends rather than to maintain an impartial order; in periods of tension, Muslims know that the armed police prefer to ask the Hindus and shoot the Muslims [Rai 1999]. Until these deficiencies are decisively addressed, it is hard to see why any of UP's marginalised groups can have the sense of security that is necessary for them to build the 'sinews of aspiration as a cultural capacity' [Appadurai 2004:75].^[PW]

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Notes

- 1 This article is a revised version of the introduction to our forthcoming book, *Confronting Saffron Demography*, Three Essays Collective, New Delhi, 2005.
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- 3 This may be because 'population sciences' in India is increasingly driven by the interests of foreign donors, and key institutions have 'failed to attract outstanding economists and sociologists with a vision of development' and have restricted their activities to data gathering, almost entirely through large-scale sample surveys [Bose 2003].
- 4 Few scheduled caste people in Bijnor described themselves as dalits. A few said they were Buddhists. 'SC' or 'harijan' were more commonly heard, both as self- and other-referents.
- 5 There are many reasons why the picture we paint may not apply elsewhere in India – especially in the south, in West Bengal, or in western India. For details of variability in, for example, the position of Muslim women across the country, see Hasan and Menon (2004).

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